

OCTOBER

EUROPE

Fiera del Tartufo, Alba, Italy

Historic Alba's White Truffle Festival is an unforgettable experience for lovers of the "white diamond," with its truffle fair, market, and (for top chefs and gourmet millionaires only) auction. Many of Alba's restaurants have special menus, or will simply shave the truffle over risotto or pasta — perfect with a glass or two of delicious Barolo wine. www.fieradeltartufo.org

Fiesta de Exaltación del Marisco, O Grove, Spain

Over ten days of seafood heaven, the small fishing community of O Grove becomes an aromatic market teeming with mussels, oysters, scallops, crabs, clams, octopus, hake, sea bass, turbot, and sole. Sample them, fresh or cooked, with a glass of the local Rías Baixas wine, while enjoying Galician-Portuguese folk dancing and Celtic *gaita* bagpipes.

Fête des Vendanges de Montmartre, Paris, France

In 1933, the citizens of Montmartre resurrected a tiny vineyard only streets away from Sacré-Coeur. Ever since, they've rejoiced in the harvest and auctioned the wine off for charity. The festival is now so popular that hundreds of thousands of celebrants fill the streets to revel in the vintners' parades, live music, theater, and poetry, and buy wines from all over France.

Salone del Gusto, Turin, Italy

Showcase of the Slow Food Movement, the biennial Salon of Taste attracts exhibitors from around the world. Seasonality, locale, and quality are essential criteria for the cured meats, fish, vegetables, cheeses, fruits, and breads on display here. www.salonedelgusto.it

THE MIDDLE EAST AND AFRICA

Fête des Dattes, Erfoud, Morocco

With nearly a million date palms to harvest, it's not surprising that the people of Erfoud celebrate the year's sweet, sticky harvest with such zeal. For three days they feast and dance to traditional music; then comes the climax, a thrilling camel race into the dunes of the Sahara.



ASIA AND AUSTRALASIA

Crave Sydney, Australia

With a whole month of over 600 diverse gastronomic events across the city, Sydney is the place to be in October, with gourmet dinners, night noodle markets, pop-up barbecues, and bush tucker experiences. But the showpiece is Breakfast on the Bridge, when the traffic stops and the Harbour Bridge is grassed over for a grand picnic. www.cravesydney.com

Phuket Vegetarian Festival, Thailand

In this extraordinary but energetic and colorful festival, participants abstain from meat and other stimulants to expunge evil spirits and bring good luck. Vegetarian dishes are eaten, but not everyone will have the stomach for the fire-walking and outlandish body piercing displays by entranced Ma Song devotees. www.phuketvegetarian.com

NORTH AMERICA

American Royal Barbecue, Kansas City, Missouri, USA

Claiming to be the largest barbecue competition in the world, the American Royal attracts hundreds of tongs-bearing, apron-wearing, grill-firing teams from across the US. To the rhythms of live bands they cook brisket, pork ribs, pork, and chicken for the title, with a sauce competition as a bonus. Most important, though, it's all tastable. www.arbbq.com

World Championship Gumbo Cook-Off, New Iberia, Louisiana, USA

On the banks of the Bayou Teche, picturesque Boulogny Plaza is filled with makeshift kitchens, and tantalizing aromas waft into the sultry air. Saturday begins with traditional jambalaya, *étouffée*, boudin, and fried fish; then, on Sunday, the great Cook-Off gets under way. Around 12,000 lb (5,500 kg) of chicken and sausage, seafood, game, and even alligator gumbo make this a truly jumbo event.

New York City Wine and Food Festival, USA

To get an idea of the pace, excitement, and ground covered in this crammed foodie weekend, think "New York Marathon

meets Woodstock meets Iron Chef." From meatballs to master chefs, fizzy drinks to finest New World wines, Blumenthal to Bourdain, there is something for everyone of every age. Book early. www.nycwineandfoodfestival.com

SOUTH AMERICA

Oktoberfest, Blumenau, Brazil

Founded in 1850 by Herman Otto Blumenau, his namesake city is a mini-Germany in the south of Brazil, but there's nothing small about their Oktoberfest. Over two weeks, a million party-lovers crowd the streets for the brightly costumed parades, marching bands, folk dancing, authentic German cuisine, and, of course, the local brews.

NOVEMBER

EUROPE

Les Trois Glorieuses, Beaune, France

It's been called "the greatest eating and drinking experience on the face of the planet," and certainly the Three Glorious Days, centered on Burgundy's famed charity wine auction, live up to their name. Tickets for Monday's eight-hour lunch at Château Meursault are beyond the reach of most, but everyone can enjoy the open-house tastings and the festive atmosphere that pervades noble Beaune and its vineyard villages.

Olioliva, Imperia, Liguria, Italy

Liguria's tiny purple Taggiasca olive is said to produce the finest olive oil in the world — mellow, woody, peppery, and utterly delicious. Imperia welcomes the new season's oil with a huge street market, and visitors from all over northern Italy and nearby Provence come to sample and buy — not just oils but Liguria's famed pesto, focaccia, and Cinque Terre wines too.

Ziebel Märkt, Bern, Switzerland

Bern's medieval Onion Market begins as you would expect. Hundreds of stands are laden with every kind of allium — braided, bouqueted, decorated, and turned into all sorts of tasty onion-flavored products — as well as lots of other hearty

